



5 The novel and short story: narrative method

Literary forms · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Prose fiction is shaped by narrative method: who tells the story (narrative voice/point of view), how time is organised (chronology, flashback, pacing), and how much the narrator reveals or withholds. Short stories typically compress these choices — often using a single significant moment, a limited cast, or an open ending — while novels can develop narrative method across multiple strands, subplots, and shifts in perspective over a longer span.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Consider an invented short story that ends mid-action, with the final line: 'She reached for the door, and the house held its breath.' The open ending withholds resolution, forcing the reader to infer the outcome from earlier established tension; this exemplifies how short fiction often relies on implication and compression rather than full narrative closure to create lasting effect.

Quick check · multiple choice

Which of the following best distinguishes typical short story form from typical novel form?
A Short stories cannot use first-person narration
B Short stories often compress action around a single moment or limited scope, while novels typically develop plot and character across a longer, more expansive structure
C Novels always use multiple narrators
D Short stories must always have a twist ending

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Write a guided commentary plan on an invented short extract from a novel's opening page: 'The town had two clocks and neither agreed with the other, so the townspeople had long ago stopped trusting time altogether.' Discuss how this opening establishes narrative method (tone, implied narrator's stance, and thematic set-up) for a longer prose work. [20]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [20]

- Point 1: the narrator's tone is wry/omniscient, positioned above individual characters, suggesting a narrative method that will observe the town collectively before individuating characters.
- Point 2: the detail of clocks disagreeing sets up a thematic preoccupation with unreliable measurement/order, likely to recur as a structural motif across the novel.
- Point 3: the phrase 'stopped trusting time altogether' hints at a possible non-linear or unconventional treatment of chronology later in the narrative.
- Point 4: the impersonal, generalising register ('the townspeople') suggests an initial distance from individual psychology, priming a shift to closer focalisation once specific characters are introduced.
- Conclusion: argue that openings encode a 'contract' with the reader about narrative method that the rest of the work will follow or deliberately subvert.

Quick check answer

B. Compression versus expansion is the key structural distinction, not narration type or the presence of a twist.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English A: Literature guide (2019).

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